

The Ottoman Empire

For over 600 years the Ottoman Empire dominated the political and religious life of the Middle East, viewed with awe by the Christian West, and a byword for wealth, power, unimaginable opulence, and—in its latter years—widespread corruption.



The harem of the Topkapi Palace
This 18th-century miniature by Fazil Enderuni shows concubines bathing in the Topkapi Palace harem. All concubines were non-Muslim captives taken in war or bought from slavers.

BEFORE

The Ottoman Empire was forged in a bloody furnace of continual intrigue and conflict.

THE CREATION OF THE EMPIRE

In the 13th century a band of **Turkish warriors** led by **Ertughrul** and his son **Osman** << 206–07 came to Anatolia from the Central Asian Plains. Ertughrul came to the aid of the Seljuk Sultan Kaihusrev II and was rewarded with land, which grew to become the *Osman-ili*, the Ottoman Empire.



SIPAHİ WARRIOR

JANISSARIES

Osman's son, **Orhan**, formed the “akinci” (standing cavalry formations) and the

celebrated “janissaries” (highly trained infantry). With this formidable army, Orhan and his son **Murad I** seized most of the Balkans, and achieved the Ottoman goal of conquering Anatolia. The **Sipahis** were mounted warriors in the army recruited from land-owning Turks. They considered themselves an elite force.

EMPIRE ACHIEVED

After defeat by the Mongols at Ankara in 1402, the reigns of **Murad II** and **Mehmed II** << 207 finally saw the Ottoman empire restored.

The emergence of the Ottomans as a world power began with the rule of Mehmed II in 1451. Mehmed led his army west to attack Christian Constantinople, capital of the once-great Byzantine Empire (see pp.198–99). Using the world's largest cannon to pound the allegedly “impregnable” walls, and with more than 160,000 men against the defenders' 7,000, he swiftly crushed all resistance. On May 29, 1453 Constantinople fell. Mehmed pushed on into Europe, seizing territory, until his failure to take Belgrade in 1456 brought the conquest to a halt and left the Ottoman Empire's border with Western Europe static for the next 60 years.

Meanwhile, the Ottoman eastern borders were threatened by the rise of the Persian Safavids. It was not until the Battle of Chaldiran in 1514 that Selim I humbled the rival dynasty. A great expansion followed. Selim led his troops east and south, taking Jerusalem's holy sites and conquering Cairo in 1517. Selim's son, Suleyman, known as “The Magnificent” in Europe for his wealth and power, proved no less a conqueror than his father. Despite his success, Suleyman's personal life ended in tragedy.

Suleyman's two favorite sons, Mustafa and Bayazid, were accused of conspiring against him. To save his throne, Suleyman was forced to have them both executed. He never



Dagger and scabbard

Ottoman weaponry was renowned for its beauty and functionality. This dagger and scabbard, richly encrusted with semiprecious stones, was probably the possession of an Ottoman noble.

recovered from this loss and, a sad and broken figure, became a virtual recluse in the Topkapi Palace, leaving his Grand Vizier (chief minister) to run the empire. While both Mustafa and Bayazid had been trained to rule, the grieving Suleyman had left Selim, his untutored surviving son, in the febrile atmosphere of the harem (the women's area of the palace). This neglect had disastrous consequences for Ottoman rule.

Ottoman decline

Many historians date the beginnings of decline from the accession of Selim, known as “the Drunkard.” With no political or military training, Selim's formative experiences were food, drink, and women. On his accession Selim handed over control of the empire to his vizier. This set the pattern for the next century of Ottoman rule, with catastrophic results.

Without a strong ruler, government corruption flourished, and the indifference of the bureaucracy to predatory local officials eroded public support for the regime. Lacking the controlling hand of the sultan, the

RULER OF OTTOMAN EMPIRE (1520–66)

SULEYMAN

This king is known as “Suleyman the Magnificent” in the Western world and in the Islamic world as *Kanuni*, “the Lawgiver”—a tribute to the prosperity his reign brought to the Ottoman Empire. Suleyman believed himself to be the spiritual heir to both Alexander (see pp.96–97) and Caesar (see pp.108–09), and claimed title to all the lands they had ruled over. Within a year of his accession, his armies had taken Belgrade, and by the time of his death the Ottomans controlled large parts of southeast Europe, the North African coast, and the Middle East. His rule saw a cultural renaissance of Islamic civilization. His support of the arts and the rule of law that he implemented remain his legacy.

